walking to the nearest supply of water. Many children miss out on an education because they are collecting water.

“The world has not really woken up to the reality of what we are going to face in terms of the crises as far as water is concerned.”

Rajendra Pachauri

Former IPCC Chair

Wildlife concerns

The water crisis is bad for humans and can mean extinction for some animals and reduction in numbers for others. Populations of the Amazon river dolphin, which lives in the Amazon and Orinoco river basins in South America, for example, have been much reduced, partly by the increase of heavy metal pollution from mining but also by the construction of dams, which restrict the migration of fish, the dolphins’ food, to their spawning grounds. Elsewhere, in China, the world’s largest amphibian, the Chinese giant salamander, has also become critically endangered by dams being built for water storage and hydroelectric power. Such engineering works change the natural flow of rivers, upsetting the creature’s habitat.

A holistic view of ecosystem management is crucial to prevent the water crisis from getting much worse. For example, a sewage treatment plant run on “clean” energy can provide the wastewater needed to fertilize biofuel crops, which in turn can be used to purify the water—without emitting greenhouse gases.

Drinkable wastewater

New technologies can also convert wastewater directly into drinkable water—a process that has been energy-hungry in the past. The Intergovernmental Panel on Climate Change (IPCC) stresses that water management policies can lead to higher greenhouse gas emissions. However, that is not the case